

Local Government in Rural Areas

1. Introduction

- India has about 6 lakh villages, 8,000 towns, and 4,000+ cities.
 - Nearly two-thirds of India's population lives in rural areas.
 - Local problems such as roads, water supply, schools, and land disputes are handled through local self-government institutions.
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2. Panchayati Raj System

- The Panchayati Raj system is the local self-government system in rural areas.
- It brings governance closer to the people and encourages participation in decision-making.
- It helps:
 - Solve local problems
 - Promote development
 - Implement government schemes at the grassroots level

Three-Tier Structure

Level	Institution
Village Level	Gram Panchayat (Village Parishad)
Block Level	Panchayat Samiti (Mandal Parishad)
District Level	Zila Parishad (District Panchayat)

3. Functions of Panchayati Raj Institutions

These institutions work in areas such as:

- Agriculture
- Housing
- Roads
- Water resources
- Education

- Health care
 - Social welfare
 - Cultural activities
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4. Gram Sabha

- Consists of all adult villagers registered as voters.
- Men and women participate equally.
- Discusses local issues and takes decisions.
- Elects the members of the Gram Panchayat.

Key Point

Gram Sabha = All Adult Voters

5. Gram Panchayat

- Lowest and most important level of Panchayati Raj.
- Members are elected by the Gram Sabha.
- Responsible for local administration and development.

Sarpanch / Pradhan

- Head of the Gram Panchayat.
- Elected leader of the village.
- Increasing participation of women as Sarpanchs.

Support Staff

Panchayat Secretary

- Calls meetings.
- Maintains records.
- Handles administrative work.

Patwari

- Maintains land records.
 - Keeps maps and land-related documents.
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6. Inspirational Sarpanchs

Dnyaneshwar Kamble

- **Transgender Sarpanch of Tarangfal village, Maharashtra (2017).**
- **Motto: "Lok Seva, Gram Seva" (Service to the village is service to the public).**

Vandana Bahadur Maida

- **First female Sarpanch of Khankhandvi village, Madhya Pradesh.**
- **Belongs to the Bhil community.**
- **Worked on education and sanitation.**

Popatrao Baguji Pawar

- **Sarpanch of Hiware Bazar, Maharashtra.**
 - **Promoted:**
 - **Rainwater harvesting**
 - **Watershed conservation**
 - **Tree plantation**
 - **Transformed the village into a prosperous model village.**
 - **Received Padma Shri (2020).**
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7. Child-Friendly Panchayat Initiative

- Ensures children's voices are heard in governance.
- Encourages participation through:
 - Bal Sabhas
 - Bal Panchayats

Objectives

- Protect children's rights.
- Improve education and wellbeing.
- Prevent child labour and child marriage.

Example: Maharashtra

- Bal Panchayats helped:
 - Bring children back to school.
 - Reduce child labour.
 - Prevent child marriages.

8. Child-Friendly Gram Panchayat Example

Sangkhu Radhu Khandu Gram Panchayat (Sikkim)

- Built school boundary walls for safety.
 - Constructed kitchens for hygienic midday meals.
 - Recognized as a child-friendly Gram Panchayat.
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9. Children's Parliament (Rajasthan)

- Started through Bunker Roy's Barefoot College.

- **Children aged 8–14 years participate.**
- **Functions like a real parliament:**
 - **Elections**
 - **Campaigning**
 - **Voter IDs**
 - **Cabinet formation**

Achievements

- **Promoted:**
 - **Education**
 - **Sanitation**
 - **Social equality**
 - **Received the World's Children's Honorary Award (2001).**
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10. Panchayat Samiti

- **Functions at the Block Level.**
- **Acts as a link between:**
 - **Gram Panchayat**
 - **Zila Parishad**
- **Coordinates development plans from different villages.**
- **Helps obtain funds for projects and schemes.**

Example

- **Supports implementation of the Pradhan Mantri Gram Sadak Yojana for all-weather rural roads.**
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11. Zila Parishad

- **Functions at the District Level.**
- **Coordinates activities across the district.**

- Integrates development plans received from Panchayat Samitis.
 - Helps distribute resources and funds.
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12. Representation and Reservation

- Special provisions exist for disadvantaged groups.
 - One-third of seats are reserved for women at all three levels.
 - Ensures wider participation in democracy.
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13. Panchayati Raj and Democracy

Democracy works through:

1. Direct participation (Gram Sabha)
2. Elected representatives (Panchayats)

Importance

- Encourages self-governance.
 - Increases people's participation.
 - Helps solve local problems efficiently.
 - Promotes rural development.
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14. Ancient Indian Roots of Local Governance

Kautilya (Chāṇakya) and the Arthaśhāstra

- Written about 2,300 years ago.
- Described an administrative system from villages to provinces.

Shows that local governance has deep roots in Indian history.

figure 11.1 needs to be added in short notes.